Inventory Bot User Guide

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Welcome

This bot keeps track of your shop's stock for you. You chat with it on Telegram, the way you would message a friend, and it keeps your Google Sheet up to date. No spreadsheet work, no calculator.

You can:

- **Tell it what happened:** "We sold 2 kg of apples" or "A supplier brought 60 packets of biscuits".
- **Ask it questions:** "Is there any bread left?" or "What is running low?"
- **Count your shelves:** it shows you what is missing compared with what the records say.

It adds up the money for you. After every sale it lists each item with its price and gives you the total to charge the customer, so you never need a calculator. After a delivery, it shows what you paid. Type your messages in words or numbers. The bot does not understand voice notes or photos yet.

Why shop owners like it

You do not need a till, a scanner or a computer. You need the phone you already have and a Google Sheet you already know how to open. Here is how it answers the worries most shop owners tell us about.

If you worry that...	The bot helps by...
I cannot be in the shop all day	You check stock, sales and profit from your phone, wherever you are
Stock goes missing and nobody knows how	Every change is saved with who made it and when, and a stock count shows any gap
I only notice an item is finished when a customer asks	It warns you when stock runs low, and sends an email every evening

If you worry that…	The bot helps by…
I do not really know my profit	It tells you the profit for the day, the week or the month
My staff are not good with computers	They type a normal message, like "sold 2 breads", and the bot asks them to confirm
Shop software is expensive and complicated	There is nothing to install and no special equipment to buy
What if I stop using it one day	Your records live in your own Google Sheet, so they are always yours

An honest note. The bot records what you and your team tell it. It is not a till that scans every sale by itself. That is why it keeps a full history, counts your stock and warns you about unusual changes. If you later want faster entry, a barcode scanner can be added (see Using a barcode scanner).

Before you start

Only people on your approved list can change stock. If someone else messages the bot, it politely refuses and nothing changes.

Get yourself on the list

1. Open Telegram and find your inventory bot. Your installer will tell you its name.
2. Press **Start**, then send the message `/myid`.
3. The bot replies with a number. That is your chat ID. Send it to the person who set up your system.
4. Once you are added, send `help` to see a short reminder of what the bot understands.

Two kinds of people

	Manager	Staff
Record sales (stock going out)	Yes	Yes
Ask questions about stock	Yes	Yes
Record deliveries, correct stock, change prices, add new products	Yes	No

	Manager	Staff
Send files and count stock	Yes	No
Receive alerts about unusual activity	Yes	No

This is enforced by the bot itself, not just by trust. If a staff member tries to add stock, correct stock, create a product, send a file or count stock, the bot replies "Only a manager can..." and nothing changes. It makes no difference whether they type a shortcut or a full sentence. Anyone who is not on your list cannot change anything at all.

Check your sheet first. Every product should be listed with its quantity, unit (kg, packet, bottle), reorder level and prices. The bot can only update products that are in the sheet.

Recording sales and deliveries

Write the way you would tell a colleague. The bot reads your sentence, shows what it understood and waits for your **YES** before changing anything.

You write	The bot understands
We sold two kilos of apples and 4 mangoes today	Take out 2 apples and 4 mangoes
A supplier brought 60 packets of biscuits	Put in 60 biscuits
A customer took 3 breads at 60 each	Take out 3 bread, priced at 60

What happens next

1. The bot replies with what it understood, for example: "I understood: 1. remove 2 apples 2. remove 4 mangoes. Reply YES to apply this, or NO to cancel. Nothing has been changed yet."
2. Reply **YES** if it is right. The bot updates your stock and sends a receipt with each item, its price and the total.
3. Reply **NO** if it is wrong. Nothing changes, and you can write it again.

If you wait more than 15 minutes, the request expires and nothing changes. Just send it again.

If the bot is not sure about a quantity or a product, it asks you a short question instead of guessing. Answer it and carry on. Short messages like `remove 5 milk` skip the YES step and run straight away, so check the spelling before you send.

Asking questions

Questions never change anything, so the bot answers straight away.

You can ask	For example
How much of one product is left	Is there any bread left?
What is running low	What is running short this week?
Everything in stock	`list`
What your stock is worth	`value` or `value mangoes`
Money in and out	How much did we sell this month? Or `totals today`
What changed recently	`history` or `history apples`

Do not worry about exact spelling. Capital letters, plurals ("apple" or "apples") and extra words like "packets" are fine. If you make a small typo, the bot suggests the product it thinks you meant.

Shortcuts, if you like them

You never have to use these, because plain sentences work. But once you know them, they are quicker. They run immediately with no YES step.

Type this	What it does
`add 20 bread`	Puts 20 bread in (a delivery)
`remove 5 milk` or `sell 5 milk`	Takes 5 milk out (a sale or loss)
`remove 2 apples, 4 mangoes, 60 biscuits`	A whole sale in one message, with a priced receipt
`remove 3 bread at 60`	Uses 60 as the price for this sale only
`set 30 bread`	Sets bread to exactly 30
`create Bottled Water 100 bottle 20`	Adds a new product: name, quantity, unit, reorder level

Type this	What it does
`dry run remove 5 milk`	Shows what would happen and what it costs, without changing anything

Use a comma between items, or put each on its own line. You can also use a product code such as `P001` instead of a name.

Prices and totals

The bot picks the right price for you, so you can read the total straight off the receipt and quote it to a customer.

- **Things that go out** (sales) use your **selling price**.
- **Things that come in** (deliveries) use your **cost price**, what you paid.
- **A different price for one sale:** add `at` and the price, for example `remove 3 bread at 60`.

A receipt looks like this:

```
Stock updated

1. Apples: 2 kg x KES 45 = KES 90
2. Mangoes: 4 kg x KES 50 = KES 200
3. Biscuits: 60 packet x KES 35 = KES 2,100

Total at selling price: KES 2,390
```

How the total is worked out. Each line is the quantity times the price, and the total is all the lines added together. In the example, 2 x 45 = 90, 4 x 50 = 200 and 60 x 35 = 2,100, which makes 2,390. For a delivery, the bot adds up the cost prices and calls the total "Stock in at cost price". Your manager can also ask `value` to see what all the stock on the shelves is worth, and `totals week` to see money in and out over the last 7 days.

Want to quote a customer without selling yet? Put `dry run` in front, for example `dry run remove 2 apples, 4 mangoes`. You get the total and nothing changes. If a product has no price in your sheet, the bot says so and leaves it out of the total.

Changing a price

When the price of something changes, tell the bot. You no longer need to edit the sheet by hand. Managers only.

- **In words:** "Change bread selling price to 60" or "Bread now costs us 45". The bot repeats what it understood and waits for your **YES**.
- **As a shortcut:** `price bread cost 45 sell 60`. You can give only the cost or only the selling price, for example `price bread sell 60`. For several products: `price bread sell 60, milk cost 40 sell 55`.
- **To check first:** put `dry run` in front and nothing changes.

The bot replies with the old and new price for each product, and warns you if a selling price is below the cost price. Every price change is saved in the Change Log with your name. Sales you already recorded keep the price they were recorded with. Only new sales and deliveries use the new price.

To see a product's current prices, ask "what is the price of bread?" or send `value bread`.

Adding a new product

Write it as you would say it: "New product: bottled water, 100 bottles, reorder at 20, cost 40, sell 55". Managers only.

1. The bot lists what it understood: the name, how many you have, the unit, the reorder level and the prices.
2. Check it, then reply **YES** to create the product or **NO** to cancel.
3. If something is missing, such as the unit or the reorder level, the bot asks for it and creates nothing until you give it.

The reorder level is the quantity at which you want a low-stock alert. Cost and selling price are optional, but without them the bot cannot work out totals for that product, so add them. If the product already exists, the bot tells you and does not create a copy. The shortcut still works: `create Bottled Water 100 bottle 20 cost 40 sell 55`.

Counting your stock

This is how you find out whether anything has gone missing. Managers only. Do it once a week, or whenever you suspect a problem.

1. Count what is really on your shelves.
2. Send the counts: `count apples 48, mangoes 40, biscuits 400`. You can also say it in words: "I counted 48 kg of apples on the shelf".
3. The bot compares your counts with the sheet and shows the difference for each product, valued at cost price. For example: "Apples: sheet 50 kg, counted 48 kg, difference -2 kg (-KES 60 at cost)".
4. Nothing has changed yet. Reply **YES** to correct the sheet to match your counts, or **NO** to leave it.

When you say YES, the corrections are saved in the record under your name. A product with no difference is simply reported as matching. You only need to count the products you want to check.

Updating many products from a file

For a big delivery or a full stock list, send a spreadsheet instead of typing every line. Managers only.

1. Make a **.csv**, **.xls** or **.xlsx** file with one row per change.
2. In Telegram, attach it with the paperclip and choose **File** (not Photo).
3. To test first, write `dry run` in the caption. The bot checks every row and changes nothing.
4. Send it again without the caption to apply it.

Use these column headings: Action (add, remove, set or create), Product ID, Item name, Quantity, Unit, Reorder level, Unit price, Cost price, Selling price, Request ID. You only need Action, one of Product ID or Item name, and Quantity. Here is a small example:

```
Action,Product ID,Item name,Quantity,Unit,Reorder level,Unit price,Cost
price,Selling price,Request ID
add,P001,Apples,40,kg,,,,,RESTOCK-001
remove,P008,Biscuits,20,packet,,,,,SALE-001
```

Reading the result. The bot tells you how many rows worked and how many were rejected, with the reason for each rejected row. Good rows are still applied when other rows are rejected. The same summary is emailed to the manager.

Sent the file twice by accident? Give each row its own Request ID, like RESTOCK-001. If the same file arrives again, those rows are rejected as duplicates, so stock is never added twice.

Daily sales and profit

The manager can ask how the day went at any time. Just type one of these, or ask in your own words, such as "how much did we make today?"

Type	You get
`sales today`	Today's sales, cost of goods and profit
`profit yesterday`	The same figures for yesterday
`sales week`	The last 7 days, with a line for each day
`sales month`	This month so far, with a line for each day

The reply shows your total sales, what the goods cost you, your profit and profit margin, your five best-selling products, and how much stock you received.

How profit is worked out. Profit is the selling price of each item sold, minus what that item cost you. This only works when each product has a cost price and a selling price in the Inventory sheet. If a sale has no cost price, the bot tells you, and leaves it out of the profit figure.

What counts as a sale. Every `remove` or `sold` message is counted as a sale. Stock you remove because it was damaged or lost is not a sale. Correct that with a stock count instead, and the bot will show it as a correction, not as income.

Only managers can see sales and profit. Staff can still record sales.

Your evening report

Every evening at 8pm the manager gets an email, so you know how the day went without asking. It shows:

- Total sales, cost of goods, profit and profit margin for the day
- The best-selling products
- Stock you received during the day
- Every product that is running low, with how many are left and the level where you should reorder

The same figures are saved as one new line per day in the **Daily Summary** tab of your Google Sheet. After a few weeks you can see your busy days and your best weeks, and you can draw a chart from them if you like.

The email also arrives on days with no sales, so a quiet day never goes unnoticed.

Alerts you will receive

Low stock (email). When a product falls to its reorder level, the manager gets an email naming the product, how much is left and the reorder level. You get one email per product, not one for every sale. After you restock it, the alert is ready to fire again. When you import a file, low items are listed in the import summary instead.

Unusual activity (Telegram message to managers). Managers are told right away when someone else:

- records a single change worth KES 10,000 or more;
- sells below cost price, or at a discount using `at`;
- sets stock lower than it was.

The message names the person and the product so you can ask about it. Your own changes do not alert you. Your installer can adjust the KES 10,000 limit.

Using a barcode scanner

You can use the bot as it is today with product names, such as `remove 2 bread`. If you want to work faster, you can add a barcode scanner later. It is an optional upgrade, and nothing else changes.

How it works. Each product's barcode is typed once into the **Barcode** column of the Inventory sheet. After that:

Send	What happens
Scan a product	The bot records a sale of 1
`6161100000012 x3`	A sale of 3 of that product
`add 6161100000012 24` (manager)	Adds 24 to your stock
`stock 6161100000012`	Shows how many are left

If you scan a code the bot does not know, it tells you and changes nothing. Ask the manager to add that barcode to the sheet.

Without a scanner. The numbers are printed under every barcode, so you can type them. A free scanner app on your phone can also read the code, and you paste the number into the chat.

With a scanner. Many Bluetooth scanners work like a keyboard. You pair one with your phone, scan, and the number is sent to the bot. Ask us to check that your scanner model works before you buy it.

Who did what

Every change is saved in your Google Sheet, together with the name of the person who made it. Open the **Inventory Change Log** tab to see the time, product, old and new quantity, the action, and whether it worked. The **Value Ledger** tab shows the money for each change.

Tab	What you will find
Inventory	One row per product: quantity, unit, reorder level, prices
Inventory Change Log	Every change or attempt, with who, when and the result
Value Ledger	The price used and the total for each change

Change prices and reorder levels in the Inventory tab. Avoid typing quantities over by hand. Use the bot, so the change is recorded with a name.

Why you can trust the numbers

The bot checks every change before it touches your sheet, and it never guesses.

- It says "not found" for a product it does not know, and suggests the closest names.
- It will not take out more than you have. It tells you how much is in stock.
- It rejects zero, negative or missing quantities.
- It warns you if the unit is wrong, for example kg for something counted in packets.
- It refuses a repeated Request ID, so a file or message is never applied twice.

- After each update, it reads the sheet back to confirm the new number. If it cannot confirm, it tells you instead of saying "done".
- Every attempt, good or rejected, goes in the Change Log with a name.
- If one line in a list is wrong, the other lines still go through and the wrong one is explained.

If something goes wrong

What you see	What to do
"This chat is not authorised"	Send `/myid` and give the number to your administrator
"Only a manager can..."	That action is for managers. Ask your manager, or record a sale with `remove`
"Product not found"	Check the spelling, or send `list` to see the exact names. For a brand new product, use `create`
"Insufficient stock"	Check the amount with `stock name`. If the sheet is wrong, a manager can fix it with a stock count
"Unit mismatch"	Use the unit the product is counted in, for example packets and not kg
"I need a quantity"	Put the number before the product, for example `add 20 bread`
You said YES but "nothing is waiting to be confirmed"	The request expired after 15 minutes. Send it again
"The language service is not reachable"	Use a shortcut such as `remove 2 apples` until it comes back
A file is rejected as a duplicate	Its Request IDs were already used. Give new IDs if you really want to apply it again
The bot does not answer	Wait a minute and try again. If it is still silent, contact support

Made a mistake? Do not worry. Fix it with the opposite action (if you removed 5 by mistake, add 5), or ask a manager to correct it with `set`. Both steps stay in the record.

Need help?

If something does not work, send your administrator three things: the message you sent, the bot's reply and the time. That is usually enough to fix it quickly.

Administrator	Obiero
Email	(add your email)
Phone / WhatsApp	(add your number)
Support hours	(add your hours)